

Instructor Guide — Lesson 5: Finding Your First Opportunities

Metadata

- **Path:** Digital Independence Path
- **Course:** 17 — Skills That Pay
- **Lesson:** 5 of course — Finding Your First Opportunities
- **Ages:** 15–18
- **Format:** Live, instructor-led (video conference)
- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Tools used:** Google Docs, Canva, Notion, Email, Spreadsheets
- **Prerequisite:** Lessons 3–4 complete — every student has a written, priced service package (what they offer, who it's for, what it costs).
- **Next lesson:** Lesson 6 — building toward broader, more public outreach (not covered here).

Overview

This lesson answers the question students are actually stuck on after pricing their service: "Okay... who do I even offer this to?" The answer this lesson teaches is deliberately narrow and safe: **start with people you or your family already know and trust** — the "warm network" — not strangers on the internet. Students will learn the difference between a warm network and cold outreach, see why warm-network-first is both safer and more realistic for a first client at their age, and build their own First Opportunity Map (the worksheet) listing real people/organizations, matched to a real adult who will be looped in before any actual conversation happens.

This is a safety-forward lesson. The instructor should treat the "always involve a trusted adult" message with the same seriousness as the pricing math in Lesson 4 — it is not a disclaimer, it is the core skill being taught.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to: 1. Define "warm network," "referral," "cold outreach," and "trusted adult" in their own words. 2. Explain two reasons warm-network-first is safer and more realistic than cold-pitching strangers. 3. List at least 8 real people/organizations in their own warm network. 4. Identify which trusted adult they would loop in for each potential opportunity. 5. Produce a shortlist of 3 first outreach targets, each with an adult assigned.

Instructor Prep (before class)

- Review each student's Lesson 3–4 service package (from their Google Doc) so you can reference their specific offer during the demo and activity.
- Have the fictional "warm network" demo pre-built in Canva or a Notion page (a simple people/organization map — see Live Demo section) so you're not building it from scratch on screen.
- Open a blank Spreadsheet or Notion table to model the First Opportunity Map live.
- Confirm every student has a parent/guardian contact on file per platform policy — this lesson explicitly assumes real conversations happen only with an adult present or pre-briefed.
- Have 2–3 real (non-identifying) examples ready of how a first client came through a school club, a family friend, or a teacher referral — concrete stories land better than abstractions at this age.

Materials Checklist

- ☐ Student's completed Lesson 3–4 service package (Google Doc)
- ☐ Blank First Opportunity Map worksheet (Spreadsheet or Notion, one per student)
- ☐ Instructor demo board (Canva or Notion) — fictional student warm-network map
- ☐ Safety checklist (in Worksheet.md) displayed on screen during the safety segment
- ☐ Email open for showing what a real referral-ask email/message looks like (template only, not sent live)

Teaching Sequence

1. Warm-Up & Hook (5 min)

Ask: "If you needed \$20 fast and could only ask people you already know, who's your first call?" Take 2–3 verbal answers. Point out: nobody said "a stranger on the internet." That instinct — start close, start trusted — is exactly the skill for today.

2. Warm Network vs. Cold Outreach (10 min)

Direct instruction. Define both terms clearly (see Key Terms in Student_Lesson.md — introduce the same definitions here so language matches): - **Warm network:** people and organizations you or your family already have a real relationship with — they know your name, or one call to a shared contact gets you introduced. - **Cold outreach:** contacting someone you have no connection to at all, hoping they'll respond — a stranger, a random business, a stranger's online listing.

Talking points: - At 15–18, your warm network is bigger than you think: school clubs, teachers, coaches, family friends, neighbors, your parents' coworkers, local shop owners who know your family, community/religious/youth organizations. - Warm network first isn't a lesser path — it's how nearly all real first jobs happen at any age. Referrals convert far more often than cold pitches because trust is already halfway built. - For a teen specifically, it's also the

safe path: every one of these contacts is reachable through, or already known to, an adult in your life. That's what makes real conversations possible safely.

3. Live Demo: Mapping a Fictional Student's Warm Network (15 min)

Introduce fictional student "Jordan R.," a 16-year-old who built a Canva-flyer-design service package in Lessons 3–4 (\$15 per flyer). On the shared screen, build Jordan's warm network map live, category by category, narrating your thinking out loud:

- **School clubs/organizations:** Jordan is in the Yearbook Club and the school's Spanish Club — both regularly need flyers for events.
- **Family friends:** Jordan's mom's coworker runs a small home-baking business and posts on a neighborhood app; she's mentioned needing "something that looks nicer" for her price list.
- **Local small businesses/community orgs (with parent involvement):** the family's dentist's office has a plain paper flyer in the waiting room for a kids' dental-health month; Jordan's dad knows the office manager.
- **Teacher/mentor referrals:** Jordan's art teacher knows the school's PTA is looking for someone to redesign the fall carnival flyer.
- **School-sanctioned platforms:** the school's student job board / activities newsletter, where opportunities are posted and vetted by school staff.

For each entry, model filling in the same four columns students will use: Person/Organization, Possible Need, How I'd Reach Out, Adult Involved. Emphasize that "Adult Involved" is never blank — Jordan's mom, dad, or the art teacher is named every time.

4. Discussion Questions (5 min)

Pose to the group (chat or verbal): 1. "Look at your own week — what's one club, team, or group you're already part of that might need what you offer?" 2. "Who's an adult in your life who knows a lot of other adults — a parent, coach, or teacher? What could you ask them?" 3. "Why might a referral from someone who already trusts you be easier to turn into a real first client than posting to strangers online?"

5. Guided Activity: Map Your Own Warm Network (20 min)

Students open their own First Opportunity Map (Spreadsheet or Notion, shared from the instructor). Working solo with instructor circulating in breakout support: - Fill in at least 2 entries per category (school clubs, family friends, local business/community org, teacher/mentor, school-sanctioned platform) — minimum 8 total entries. - For every entry, name a specific trusted adult. - Circle/highlight their top 3 to carry into the "My First 3 Outreach Targets" section. - Complete the safety checklist at the bottom of the worksheet.

Instructor circulates to check: every row has a real adult named (not "TBD" or blank), and no entry is a stranger found online.

6. Lesson Close (5 min)

Recap: today's job wasn't to contact anyone yet — it was to see how much opportunity already exists in your trusted circle, and to plan who's coming with you before any real conversation happens. Preview Lesson 6: how to think

about opportunities beyond the warm network, still safely, once you've practiced with people you already know.

Common Misconceptions to Address

- **"I need to advertise to strangers online to get a real client."** Correct this directly: most first jobs at any age come through people who already know you. Strangers-online is a later, more advanced (and more supervised) step — not today's lesson, not a prerequisite for having a "real" client.
- **"My first client has to be a stranger to count as real."** A paying family friend or school club is a completely real client — the money, the deadline, and the feedback are real even though the relationship started warm. Reassure students who may feel "it doesn't count" if it's someone they know.
- **"Trusted adult involvement is just a formality/rule to check off."** Reframe: looping in an adult is a genuine part of doing this well and safely — adults often know people, can vouch for the student, and can help navigate a first real conversation.

Anticipated Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	Troubleshooting move
"I don't know 8 people/organizations"	Prompt with categories one at a time; suggest asking parents "who do you know who might need X?" as homework if the list is thin in class.
Student lists an online stranger or a marketplace account as an entry	Redirect immediately — explain that's cold outreach and out of scope for this lesson; ask them to swap it for someone in their actual life.
Student leaves "Adult Involved" blank or writes "myself"	Stop and clarify: every real client conversation needs a named adult, even if it's just "keeps my mom in the loop by text." Model the phrasing.
Student conflates a large brand/company with a "local small business"	Clarify "local" means somewhere their family has an actual connection — not a chain or company found online.
Student is shy about asking family/teachers	Normalize it — point out this is exactly what the demo modeled, and it's a low-stakes ask ("do you know anyone who might need...") not a sales pitch.

How to Review Student Work

Check each submitted First Opportunity Map for: - At least 8 total entries spanning all 5 categories (school clubs, family friends, local business/community org with parent involvement, teacher/mentor, school-sanctioned platform). - A named, real trusted adult on every row — no blanks, no "TBD." - Zero entries that are strangers, online marketplaces, or cold contacts. - A completed safety checklist with all boxes genuinely checked (not just skimmed). - A "First 3 Outreach Targets" shortlist that plausibly connects to their Lesson 3–4 service package.

Flag for a 1:1 follow-up (not a grade issue, a safety issue) any submission where an adult is missing from a real-sounding client entry, or where a stranger/online contact appears — address before the student takes any next step.

Lesson Close (Instructor Script)

"You now have a map of people who already know you — and a plan for who's coming with you before any real conversation starts. That's the safe, realistic way almost every first job happens. Next time, we'll talk about what to do once you've practiced here and are ready to think a little bigger — still safely, still with adults in the loop."